A commentary on the essence of

The Jewel Ornament of Liberation

of Dharma Lord Gampopa

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Ch. 2 The Precious Human Life

0. Precious human Life

The excellent working basis to work towards enlightenment.

1. The working basis is the precious human life.
   See, everything depends on causes and conditions. It's not just one thing or two things; many causes and conditions have to come together.

2. All sentient beings have Buddha nature. But, do all beings in the five realms (hell, hungry ghost, animal, demigod, and god) have the opportunity to achieve enlightenment?
   Gampopa says, "No."
   This means not directly.

3. Also Gampopa is not saying there are no bodhisattvas among the hell beings, hungry ghosts, animals, demigods, or gods.
   Of course there are.
   But, naturally, the ordinary beings there, in that life, don't have that opportunity.

4. Then, within the human realm, not every human being has that opportunity, but those who have the precious human life: a life which has the two qualities of leisure and endowments, and a mind which holds the three faiths (interests, trusts).
   Such one has the good basis to work towards enlightenment.

5. In summary: leisure and endowments, trust, longing, and clarity faiths; two of the body, three of the mind. These five comprise the excellent working basis.

I. Leisure

It is being free from these eight unfavorable conditions

1. What makes leisure?
   First, its opposite: the eight unfavorable conditions.
   (1) Those born in the hell realm, which is not necessarily some other place: in the human realm and in the animal realm there are individuals so tortured, constantly tortured.

2. (2) In the human and in the animal realm there are individuals who are always hungry, looking for something to drink, eat.
   (3) And there are some who are so stupid[1].
   These first three unfavorable conditions are the hell realm, the hungry ghosts or hungry spirits, and the animal realm.

[1] In a larger commentary on this section, Rinpoché elaborated on the meaning of stupidity in the case of animals: “Animals are mostly overpowered by stupidity. It is saying most, not every one. There are some who are very smart maybe sometimes smarter than human beings, but most are the overpowered by the stupidity. Like, for example to your dog or cat, you tell ‘So this is virtue, practice. This is non virtue, don’t practice,’ they have no idea what you’re talking about. Tell them ‘You’re into samsara, you know. Maybe you want to make effort to achieve enlightenment…’ They will look at you ‘Get some food.’ Stupid in that sense.” Video at 9:54 (youtu.be/gdPFrbSTZBM)

3. (4) Even human beings:
   barbarians in the border places,
   meaning where there's no wisdom,
   right or wrong.

4. (5) Long-life gods: there are
   some who live a long life,
   but with no clarity of the mind,
   no understanding of what samsara
   is, what enlightenment is.

5. (6) Holding wrong views:
   this means basically not
   understanding causality:
   what's virtue,
   what's non-virtue, what's the
   cause of peace and happiness,
   what's the cause of suffering.

6. (7) Absence of the Buddha:
   where no Buddha has appeared,
   there are no teachings to
   study and practice how to be
   free from samsara.

7. (8) And the last, the mute:
   those who cannot communicate.

8. These are the eight
   unfavorable conditions.
   When these eight are reversed,
   free from these eight,
   then it's called leisure:
   it means one has time,
   opportunity to study and
   practice.

II. Endowment

Appreciate, rejoice, uplift yourself!

1. The ten endowments are divided
   into two: five from one's own
   side and five from others' side.

2. From one's own side,
   the five qualities that
   one needs to have oneself:
   (1) one has to be a human being,
   (2) born where there are Dharma
   teachings, and (3) having all
   the senses — you can read,
   hear, smell, think.

3. (4) Not reverting to evil deeds,
   meaning one has not done the
   heinous actions which prevent
   attaining Buddhahood in one
   lifetime; and (5) having
   devotion for the teachings,
   meaning one is interested in
   taking refuge, taking the
   precepts, and so forth.

4. The conditions or circumstances we need from outside are: (6) a Buddha has appeared in this world; (7) the Buddha taught the Dharma teachings; (8) the Dharma teaching the Buddha taught continues today; (9) there are followers of the Dharma, the teachers, the Sangha communities; and (10) there is love and kind support from others. When we practice, we need a lot of support.

5. When these two come together, this makes a body with the eight leisures and ten endowments, eighteen in all. That makes it a precious human life, such a great opportunity and condition to study and practice Dharma.

6. Just imagine: if one is missing from these eighteen, then we cannot practice Dharma. So, how rare it is!

7. Those who have this, appreciate, rejoice: "There are so many people in the world; many don't have this opportunity, and I have this. So I am so fortunate."

8. Appreciate, rejoice, uplift yourself: not out of arrogance, but out of modesty, out of wisdom, out of love and compassion.

II. A - II. B It is difficult to obtain and of great benefit

Contemplating precious human life is very important

1. It is precious for two reasons: it is difficult to obtain, and it brings great benefit.

II. A. Why it is difficult to obtain

2. You can read why it is difficult to achieve, but just one important point is: how can beings in the hell, hungry ghost, and animal realms be reborn human? To have this precious life the foundation is the five precepts (as mentioned in the Madhyamakāvatāra), which is why ethics is so important; much accumulation of merit is needed.

3. Having practiced the five precepts makes the perfect condition to be born as a human, as a precious human life.

II. B. Why it brings great benefit

4. You can read the benefits in the book, but briefly: with a precious human life, a person of modest capacity can at least be reborn human again; a person of middling capacity can become free from samsara and achieve arhatship; and a person of great capacity can become a bodhisattva and even a Buddha.

5. As Acharya Chandragomin said:
   "How great are the
   beneficial effects of
   a precious human life!
   By obtaining this precious
   human life, one can become free
   from the ocean of rebirth,"
   free from samsara.
   Beyond samsara its
   sufferings do not exist.
   Not only that, one can "sow the
   seed of supreme enlightenment,"
   which means we can cultivate
   bodhicitta.

6. At the bodhisattva vow,
   one joyfully, happily
   performs the vow, saying:
   "I cultivated aspiration and
   embraced action bodhicitta.
   I'm so grateful, so happy."
   It is because of this
   precious human life we have.
   So how precious this is!

7. Cultivating bodhicitta is the
   direct cause and consummate
   method to achieve Buddhahood.
   Because of bodhicitta we
   practice the six paramitas:
   generosity, ethics,
   patience, perseverance,
   concentration, and insight.
   All the six paramitas we can
   practice because of this
   precious human life.

Closing remarks

8. Some people think contemplating
   on the precious human
   life is not important but
   it is very important,
   to inspire ourselves to practice
   and not waste the opportunity.

9. Just as you need such a
   good car to arrive at a
   very beautiful destination,
   the car needs to have all
   the required conditions.
   Like this, the precious human
   life is like a car to drive to
   destination of enlightenment.
   Reflect on this, meditate

10. In Dharma practice,
    always you practice joyfully.
    Samsara is not the
    place to stay overtime.
    Say: "I have been in samsara so
    long; now I have this precious
    human life to be free and
    achieve enlightenment."

III. Trusting faith

It is to understand the causality of suffering and the cessation of suffering.

1. Next, the working basis is the
   mind: the mind needs interest
   to be free from samsara
   and to attain Buddhahood.
   Without interest, even with the
   opportunity, when we try to sit:
   "I want to go outside; there's
   a beautiful movie to see!"
   Sitting seems boring,
   because we have not seen the
   direct suffering of samsara.

2. Gampopa speaks of three faiths or interests: trusting faith, longing faith, and clear faith.

3. Trusting faith is the understanding of causality: that suffering has a cause, and that the cause can be avoided. When the Buddha taught the four noble truths, he said, “You should know suffering,” meaning that it is reality everyone should understand. Then he taught the truth of the cause, where the suffering is coming from. The truth of the cause is that suffering does not come without cause, nor from a wrong or incomplete cause, but from the direct, right cause. So the Buddha said, “Avoid these causes of suffering.” Understanding this is trusting faith.

4. Sometimes people think karma, emptiness, and rebirth are just Buddhist beliefs, culture, or something the Buddha created. In reality, causality is not a Buddhist belief; it is the reality of all phenomena. Through causes and conditions you can see how things are manifesting. This is very clear, obvious; we cannot ignore it; we have to be very smart.

5. In the 21st century, people are so smart and educated, yet we are completely besotted with our mental confusion.

6. For example: "I'm besotted with someone; it's taking my freedom." So our freedom is taken by our mental afflictions. Look at this: even though we know it, we sacrifice, and then we have to pay the price. The suffering is there because we create its cause of suffering.

7. Seeing the complete nature of samsara, the Buddha taught this wisdom. His wisdom is beyond measurement; his compassion is undefiled compassion, beyond measurement.

8. The Buddha taught the teachings with compassion to all sentient beings because for everyone, anywhere, everywhere, rich or poor, educated or not, human or non-human, all our concern is suffering and how to be free from it. On that basis, we make efforts and work hard, yet sometimes create more chaos, more suffering. So the Buddha taught: understand suffering and avoid the causes of suffering.

9. Then he taught that to achieve nirvana, the cessation of suffering, we follow the path: generally the thirty-seven branches of enlightenment, especially the eightfold path. First understand, then follow; that is Dharma practice. Understanding this is trusting faith.

IV. - V. Longing faith and clear faith

With it, our study and practice will be very productive.

1. Longing faith means: "Now I really desire to be free from samsara. I really desire to achieve nirvana."

2. Longing! "I'm longing to arrive at a special place." Like when we make a plan to go on a picnic to a very special place: then we are so longing to get there; we have such a strong desire to arrive at that special place. So here we are longing to be free from samsara, longing to arrive at enlightenment. It's all our mental journey. That kind of faith we need.

3. Clear faith means looking at the Buddha, who purified all the obscurations, fully awakened from the delusion, and developed all the excellent qualities.

4. As I mentioned, when you look at the mind, when negative thoughts invade your mind, where do they abide? When you look carefully, these negative thoughts, these illusions, have no place; they just dissolve into emptiness. That's taking care of the obscurations. When we are taking care of the obscurations, then the clarity, the effulgence of the mind, manifests slowly, slowly, clear.

5. Then you see: “Yes, it makes sense; everything is impermanent, everything is illusory nature.” There is great joy, happiness, which just manifests by itself, without attachment.

6. Looking at this: the Buddha achieved such excellent qualities, a very clear mind. The Dharma teaching is the wisdom the Buddha has: "I must study, I must practice the Dharma teaching for my own benefit and for others' benefit." And the Sangha, the great bodhisattvas who study and practice these, are so precious. So Buddha, Dharma, Sangha are so precious: this is clear faith.

7. We need this clear faith; with it, our study and practice will be very productive.

Concluding remarks

So that is the precious human life to reflect on.

1. Two qualities of the body,
   leisure and endowments,
   and three qualities of the mind,
   trusting, longing, and clear
   faith, make the complete,
   perfect condition to study
   and practice Dharma.
   That's what is called precious
   human life. Reflect on this;
   it is so precious.

2. Acknowledge,
   "I have this condition.
   Even though I'm getting old,
   I can make it;
   I can practice Dharma.
   Now I have a better chance,
   more opportunity to study and
   practice Dharma."

3. Reflect: "Now I have enough
   experience of samsara.
   We did it all; we went to
   so many places, on picnics,
   to the movies, all such things;
   nothing special is there.
   Now the Dharma teaching
   makes all the sense.
   I have a precious human life.
   I am so fortunate.
   I have perfect conditions and
   perfect Dharma teachings; what
   better can we get than this?
   I cannot, I dare not waste
   this opportunity."

4. "My mental afflictions have been
   playing with me for a long time,
   dragging me here, there,
   everywhere. Enough.
   Now it's time to settle down.
   I will practice Dharma,
   and I will make such a condition
   that these mental afflictions
   disappear to nowhere.
   They have no place to
   go but to disappear."
   Just meditate, because these
   mental afflictions are nothing
   but a mirage, illusory nature.

5. These mental afflictions
   obscure our mind when we
   don't have wisdom and take
   all our attention; but as
   soon as we use this wisdom,
   where do they exist?
   Then they have no life;
   they are just illusions;
   that is what illusion is about.
   A mirage, they are like a dream.
   So that is the precious human
   life to reflect on.